



Troy Masters — Candidate, West End Health Service District Board

Speaking on his own behalf; chamber title for identification only

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Masters: “I Ran the Numbers — the West End Loses \$25,000 Every Day Without a Hospital”

NUCLA, Colo. — Troy Masters, a candidate for the board of the proposed West End Health Service District on this November's ballot, says the question facing voters isn't whether the West End can afford a hospital — it's whether it can keep affording not to have one.

“Every single day, about **\$25,000** leaves this community,” Masters said. “Roughly \$22,000 of it is Medicare, Medicaid, and insurance money paid to hospitals, pharmacies, and labs in Montrose and Grand Junction for everyday care — X-rays, check-ups, prescriptions, emergency visits. The other \$3,000 is what our families spend out of their own pockets on gas, meals, and motel rooms just to get there. We never see that money leave, because the insurance companies pay it directly. But it's our money, attached to our people, and right now none of it stays.”

Masters, of Naturita, is president of the Nucla-Naturita Area Chamber of Commerce (NNACC) — which serves the same five communities the proposed district would — and co-owner of Paradox Cycle. He is speaking as an individual candidate and resident, not on behalf of the chamber; his title is noted for identification only. He says understanding the outflow is what decided his candidacy.

“As chamber president, I've spent my energy on keeping our local businesses and our community alive,” Masters said. “When I finally understood how much money leaves this community for healthcare — money we never even see, because insurance pays it straight out of town — the decision to run became both obvious and critical. You cannot build a strong local economy while nine million dollars a year walks out the door.”

Masters didn't take anyone's word for the numbers — drawing on his professional background in operations and technology, he built a public calculator to check them. The tool, available at **montrose-property-search.onrender.com**, lets any property owner look up their actual parcel and see exactly what the proposed 20-mill levy would cost them — senior exemption included — side by side with what their household spends traveling for care.

“I built it because I think voters deserve the real number for their own property, not a slogan,” Masters said. “For most households, the travel they're already paying for costs more than the levy will. Run your

own address and see.”

The outflow adds up to an estimated **\$8 to \$10.6 million every year** from the district's 2,259 residents — the population stated in the district's filed service plan. The analysis counts only care a local critical access hospital would actually provide — emergency and urgent care, primary care, imaging, labs, pharmacy, and basic hospital stays — and deliberately excludes the surgeries and specialty care that would still be referred to larger hospitals. Approximate annual breakdown:

- **\$2.7–3.2 million** in pharmacy spending
- **\$1.4–1.8 million** in emergency and urgent care
- **\$1.2–1.5 million** in primary care and check-ups
- **\$0.9–1.3 million** in imaging and lab work
- **\$0.9–1.4 million** in basic hospital stays, observation, and therapy services
- **\$0.9–1.5 million** in family travel costs (fuel, meals, lodging)

Keeping that care local would support **70–80 local jobs**, and research shows every dollar a rural hospital spends generates about **\$2.50 in local economic activity** (University of Wyoming study). The stakes of doing nothing are also documented: a University of North Carolina study found that rural communities without their sole hospital suffer a permanent **4% decline in per-capita income** and higher unemployment.

“My grandparents' generation built the roads, the schools, and the power that made it possible to live here,” Masters said. “This is our generation's version of that decision. And for our elders, it's personal — right now, when someone needs rehab or long-term care, we send them over the divide and visit when we can. A hospital with swing beds and long-term care means they stay home, with us, where they belong.”

The proposed district — covering Naturita, Nucla, Redvale, Bedrock, and Paradox — will appear on the **November 2026** ballot, along with candidates for its first elected five-member board. The filed service plan describes a critical access hospital of approximately 65,000 square feet with a preliminary project cost estimate of \$82.2 million, funded in part by the 20-mill levy (projected to generate \$949,950 in 2027).

As a board candidate, Masters says his commitment is transparency: “An elected board, public budgets, annual audits — and my promise that every number we put in front of voters will trace to a source you can check. That's how I built the calculator, and that's how I'd serve on this board. If my neighbors find an error in my math, I want to hear about it — that's the point of showing your work.”

Voters can verify the figures, look up their own property, and see the running total of healthcare dollars lost this year at **montrose-property-search.onrender.com**.

Methodology: Healthcare spending estimates are based on 2024 CMS National Health Expenditure data, CDC/NCHS emergency department utilization rates, and AHRQ cost data, applied to the district population of 2,259 stated in the filed WEHSD service

plan. Travel costs assume 2.5–3.5 out-of-town medical trips per resident per year at 100 miles each way, using the IRS \$0.70/mile rate plus meals and occasional overnight stays. Rural hospital economics: Holmes et al., *Health Services Research*; Eilrich et al. (2015). Jobs figure (70–80) from the district's filed materials.

About Troy Masters: Troy Masters lives in Naturita, where he is president of the Nucla-Naturita Area Chamber of Commerce and co-owner of Paradox Cycle. His professional background is in operations consulting, product management, and solutions architecture. Chamber affiliation is listed for identification purposes only; Mr. Masters speaks solely on his own behalf as a candidate, not for the chamber or its membership. [CAMPAIGN CONTACT]

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